

This Court has recognized inherent power in Congress to pass appropriate legislation to "preserve the departments and institutions of the general government from impairment or destruction, whether threatened by force or by corruption." *Burroughs v. United States*, 290 U. S. 534, 545 (1934). Congress has the power, for example, to restrict the political activities of civil servants, *e. g.*, *CSC v. Letter Carriers*, 413 U. S. 548 (1973); to punish bribery and conflicts of interest, *e. g.*, *Burton v. United States*, 202 U. S. 344 (1906); to punish obstructions of lawful governmental functions, *Haas v. Henkel*, 216 U. S. 462 (1910); and—with important exceptions—to make executive documents available to the public, *EPA v. Mink*, 410 U. S. 73 (1973). The Court also has recognized that in aid of such legislation Congress has a broad power "to inquire into and publicize corruption, maladministration or inefficiency in agencies of the Government." *Watkins v. United States*, 354 U. S. 178, 200 n. 33 (1957). See also *Buckley v. Valeo*, *supra*, at 137–138; *Eastland v. United States Servicemen's Fund*, 421 U. S. 491 (1975).

The legislation before us rationally serves these investigative and informative powers. Congress legitimately could conclude that the Nixon-Sampson agreement, following the recommendation of impeachment and the resignation of President Nixon, might lead to destruction of those of the former President's papers that would be most likely to assure public understanding of the unprecedented events that led to the premature termination of the Nixon administration. Congress similarly could conclude that preservation of the papers was important to its own eventual understanding of whether that administration had been characterized by deficiencies susceptible of legislative correction. Providing for retention of the materials by the Administrator and for the selection of appropriate materials for eventual disclosure to the public was a rational means of serving these legitimate congressional objectives.